exterior melted as he reportedly confessed to his crimes, soiled himself several times, and apparently sought to harm himself twice. His classmates say he never even talked about women, but police claim to have found only pornographic material and online games on his laptop.

His parents and two elder sisters—one an MSc maths student, the other pursuing an LLB—can't get over their numbed incredulity. All three siblings got free laptops from the state government after scoring above 75 per cent in their 10th boards—Niraj got his in 2017. "The sisters use it occasionally, but Niraj spent all his time on that machine. That ruined him," says a distraught Dasharatha. In 2020, Niraj got into the Vellore Institute of Technology, Bhopal, but classes were online. In these two, Covid-bitten years, excess turned into wall-to-wall obsession—and he passed through a dark mirror into contemporary India's hate-filled digital dystopia.

Politics or religion were never discussed in the Bishnoi household, but Niraj displayed enough hints of a radicalised mind. His parents are originally Rajasthan natives, but he was born in Assam and had absorbed its political anxieties. "He did not like Bangladeshis, not even those who employed them. Once he went to a housewarming party and came back without eating anything when he saw some Bangladeshi labourers," says Dasharatha. Nor did he eat out—never being sure of the food's "purity". He always wanted food cooked by his mother. In 2020, Niraj was deeply perturbed when a popular news anchor was arrested by Mumbai Police. "He usually doesn't watch the news but he remained so glued to it then his mother scolded him," says Dasharatha.

Despite his wallflower behaviour on social media, Niraj kept a Quora profile, and his words there—mostly on technology, but often taking a detour to subjects as oddly diverse as Hinduism, the black holes and Sunny Leone—offer us peeks into a mind warped by radicalism. Sample this, verbatim: "I've seen some missionaries which help people in their need, but they take advantage of their helplessness! They make them eat beef so that they can't ever be converted to Hinduism." In another diatribe, directed at Leone, he asserted that poor upbringing and greed made her choose a career in the adult entertainment industry.

# THE AUCTIONEERS OF HATE

*Four men and one woman have been arrested for creating and propagating two online apps that "auctioned" Muslim women*



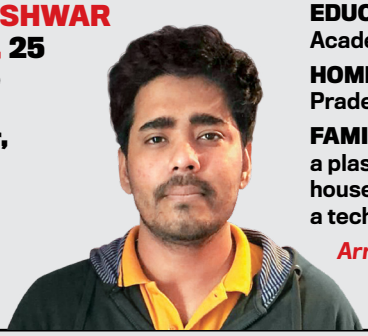
**NIRAJ BISHNOI, 21**
**Student, alleged creator of Bulli Bai app**

**EDUCATION:** 2nd year engineering student in Vellore Institute of Technology, Bhopal

**HOMETOWN:** Jorhat, Assam, originally from Rajasthan

**FAMILY:** Father is a shopkeeper, mother housewife, has two elder sisters, one doing MSc in mathematics, the other LLB

*Arrested by Delhi Police*



**OMKARESHWAR THAKUR, 25**
**Freelance code developer, alleged creator of Sulli Deals app**

**EDUCATION:** BCA from IPS Academy, Indore

**HOMETOWN:** Indore, Madhya Pradesh, originally from Bihar

**FAMILY:** Father works in a plastic factory, mother housewife. His brother is also a techie

*Arrested by Delhi Police*

**VISHAL KUMAR JHA, 21**
**Student, alleged to be involved in Bulli Bai app**

**EDUCATION:** 2nd year engineering student in Dayanand Sagar College of Engineering, Bengaluru

**HOMETOWN:** Patna

**FAMILY:** Father is a railways TTE, mother housewife. Has an elder sister who works in an MNC

*Arrested by Mumbai Police*





**SHWETA SINGH, 18**
**Student, alleged to be involved in Bulli Bai app**

**EDUCATION:** 12TH PASS

**HOMETOWN:** Rudrapur in Uttarakhand, originally from Bulandshahr in Uttar Pradesh

**FAMILY:** Father died of Covid in 2020, mother died in 2011. Lives with her siblings–an older sister, a younger sister and a younger brother

*Arrested by Mumbai Police*

**MAYANK RAWAT, 21**
**Student, alleged to be involved in Bulli Bai app**

**EDUCATION:** B.Sc. Honours in Chemistry from Delhi's Zakir Hussain College

**HOMETOWN:** Kotdwar, Uttarakhand

**FAMILY:** Father is in the army

*Arrested by Mumbai Police*